treasury savings deposit certificates, postal savings certificates and deposits, any deposit made by the assessee with the government or in any security of the government or of a local authority and amount in the credit to the provident fund. Property outside India was also excluded.

The definition of assets kept getting modified. Major amendments were carried out in 1969, 1970, 1981 and 1993. With these amendments, the definition kept getting increasingly complicated and the net of exemptions wider. Building was included but a house meant exclusively for residential purposes and one allotted by a company to an employee or an officer in whole-time employment with a gross annual salary of less than Rs 5 lakh was excluded. Any house for residential or commercial purposes that forms part of stock in trade and any house the assessee may occupy for the purposes of any business or profession carried on and residential property that had been let out for a minimum period of 300 days in the previous year and any property in the nature of commercial establishments or complexes was excluded. It is easy to imagine the kind of complexities wealth tax had gotten into. There were numerous other complications relating to other assets.

Wealth tax yielded a meagre amount of Rs 154 crore in 1993–94 (CIT, or corporate income tax, Rs 10,060 crore, PIT Rs 9123 crore). It declined rapidly for the next four years (Rs 105 crore in 1994–95, Rs 74 crore in 1995–96 and Rs 78 crore in 1996–97). It received a leg-up in 1998–99 when it reached Rs 162 crore and then again declined and remained static in the range of Rs 120–150 crore until 2004–05. In 2005–06, it increased somewhat to Rs 250 crore but its share had fallen very low in direct taxes (CIT Rs 1,01,277 crore and PIT Rs 63,629 crore). It increased steadily thereafter and grew to Rs 950 crore in 2013–14 and 2014–15. Its share in gross tax revenues was, however, less than 0.1 per cent. It had become completely insignificant.